BRITISH MUSLIM HERITAGE CENTRE

The First Word

An animated reel for the British Muslim Heritage Centre · voiceover with word-synced captions · 9:16 vertical, 1080×1920 · about 68 seconds · built in After Effects

CONCEPT

The idea

The reel opens with a question for the viewer: **what was the very first word of the Qur'an to be revealed?** The answer, *Iqra* ("Read"), starts a story told on one endless canvas styled like a sleek knowledge app.

A gold line, the pen, carries that word through 1,400 years of Muslim learning: **al-Khwārizmī in 9th-century Baghdad**, whose book gave us "algebra" and whose name gave us "algorithm"; **Fatima al-Fihri's al-Qarawiyyin in Fez**, founded in 859 and still teaching; and finally **an 1843 college building in Whalley Range that is still a place of learning: BMHC**.

When the camera pulls back, the whole network turns out to be an **Islamic eight-pointed star**. Four of its points are lit and four are still empty, and the reel hands the viewer the cursor: **what will you read next?**

HOOK · FIRST 4 SECONDS

"What was the very first word of the Qur'an to be revealed?"

END LINE

"It all began with one word. So, what will you read next?"

Every element follows the voiceover

- **Nothing appears until the voice names it.** Every chip, card, line and number enters on its own cue word, marked in the script; small labels and source tags arrive with their element.
- **The captions are the script.** Each word lights up as it is spoken. In the hook, the question types itself into a search bar in time with the voice.
- **The viewer is asked twice:** a guess at the start, with a pause to answer, and a question at the end that invites comments.

Why it works for BMHC

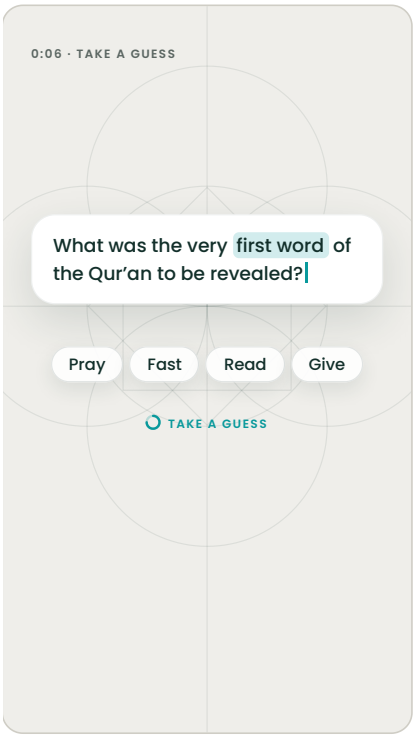
- **It puts BMHC's mission on screen:** "a centre of excellence for learning and development" that aims to "promote Muslim Heritage programmes that highlight the positive contributions of Muslims".
- **It earns interaction.** A quiz in the first 4 seconds keeps people watching for the answer. The closing question, a pinned comment and a Story quiz sticker bring in comments.
- **It speaks to everyone.** Muslims get a reminder rooted in the Qur'an; viewers of any faith or none get history worth sharing, in line with BMHC's vision of "fostering good relations between Muslims and other faith groups".
- **It leads somewhere:** to the Centre's Qur'an classes, study circles, exhibitions and youth clubs.

Why it's new

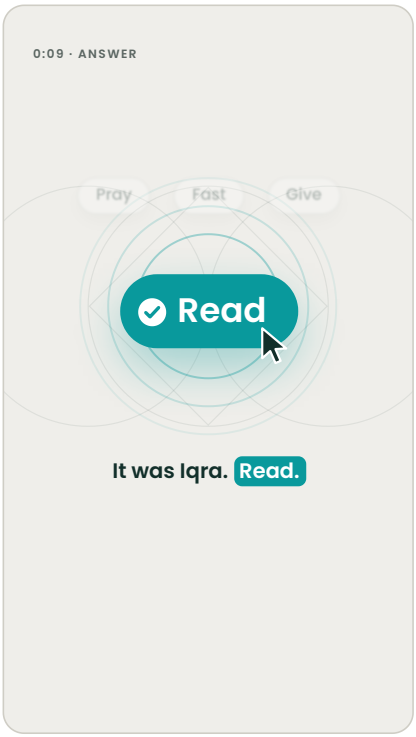
Most Islamic reels, like the two references, put a voiceover and captions over visuals that run regardless of what is being said, and most Islamic motion design on Pinterest repeats the same lanterns, crescents and mosque silhouettes. This reel looks like a premium product launch, with glass UI, a live knowledge graph and geometric construction lines in BMHC's colours, and every visual is cued by a spoken word. It ties the Qur'an, Muslim heritage and the Centre's own building into one story.

STORYBOARD: SIX KEY FRAMES

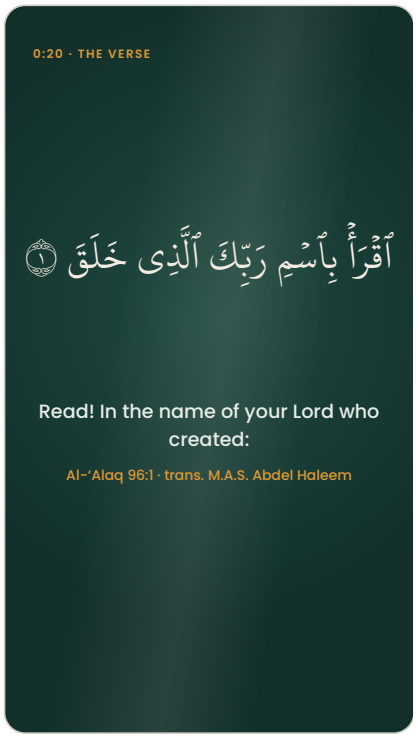
Layout sketches for the animator, shown in BMHC's colours and fonts. The final art is built in After Effects. Key content stays inside Instagram's safe area, clear of the bottom caption area and the buttons on the right.



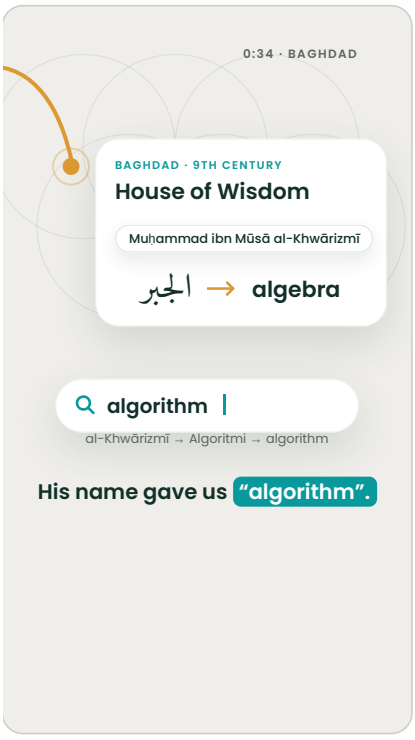
1 · Hook and guess · 0:06
The question types in as it's spoken. On "revealed?" four chips drop out, and on "guess" a countdown starts.



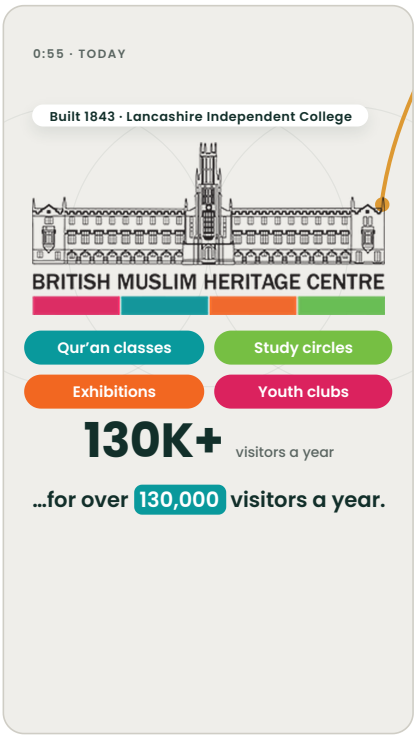
2 · Answer · 0:09
The cursor clicks "Read". The other chips fade gently, with no crosses. A source tag follows on "the Prophet".



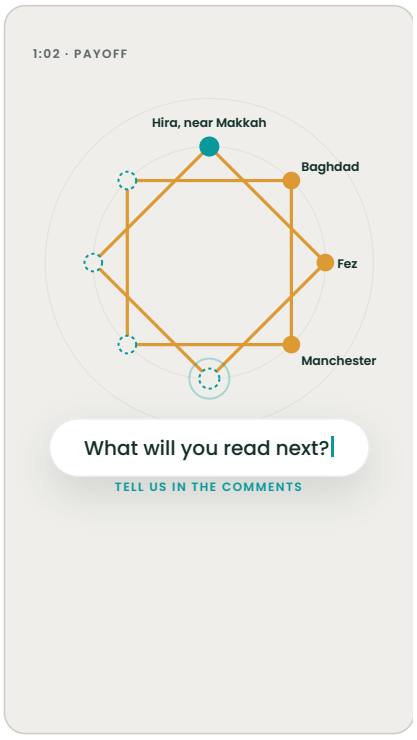
3 · The verse · 0:20
Sacred mode: the UI is gone. A soft band of light reveals the verse right to left with the imam's recitation. No effects, no SFX.



4 · Baghdad · 0:34
The pen line reaches the first node. Al-jabr rearranges into "algebra", and his name decodes into "algorithm".



5 · Manchester and today · 0:55
The building from BMHC's logo has drawn itself. Each programme pops out on its own word, then the counter rolls up.



6 · Payoff · 1:02
The knowledge graph is an eight-pointed star. Four points are lit and four wait for the viewer, and the bar returns with a question.

SCRIPT AND SYNC SHEET

About 140 spoken words plus a short recitation, around 68 seconds. The captions match the voiceover word for word, except that "peace be upon him" is shown as ﷺ and the web address as "bmhc.org.uk". **Teal words** are cue words: the element named on the right enters exactly on that word.

BEAT	VOICEOVER = CAPTIONS	ON SCREEN
1 · Hook 0:00–0:05	"What was the very **first word** of the Qur'an to be **revealed?**"	• An ivory canvas with faint compass circles. A white glass search bar springs up with a blinking cursor, and each word types in as it's spoken. • **first word** → a teal highlight slides behind those two words. • **revealed?** → four word chips drop out of the bar onto the grid: Pray · Fast · Read · Give.
2 · Guess 0:05–0:07.5	"Take a **guess**." Then 1.5 s of quiet.	• **guess** → a small label, "Take a guess", appears under the chips. A cursor glides from chip to chip, and each one lifts with a soft tick as it passes. A thin ring around the cursor closes like a countdown during the pause.
3 · Answer 0:07.5–0:13	"It was **Iqra**. **Read.** Revealed to **the Prophet Muhammad**, peace be upon him."	• **Iqra** → the cursor clicks "Read". A ripple spreads and the chip turns teal with a tick. The other three fade gently, with no red crosses, because all four are acts of worship. • **Read** → the chip glides to the centre and grows, and the bar dissolves. • **the Prophet Muhammad** → the caption reads "the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ", and a source tag fades in: "Sahih al-Bukhari 3".
4 · The verse 0:13–0:22 **Sacred mode**	BMHC's imam recites Al-'Alaq 96:1 in Arabic (about 4–6 s). Then the narrator: "**Read! In the name of your Lord who created.**"	اقْرَأْ بِاسْمِ رَبِّكَ الَّذِي خَلَقَ ﴿١﴾ • The canvas slowly darkens to BMHC deep green, and all the UI is gone. The verse appears in Uthmani script, revealed by a soft band of light that moves right to left with the recitation. • **Read! In the name…** → Abdel Haleem's translation fades in beneath, with "Al-'Alaq 96:1". • Only the light and a very slow push-in move. There's no typing, no letter effects and no sound effects. • Size this beat to the imam's actual recording. Never trim or speed up the recitation; shift the later timings instead.
5 · The pen 0:22–0:29.5	"The same revelation goes on: '**who taught by means of the pen**.' And **a whole civilisation picked up the pen**."	الَّذِي عَلَّمَ بِالْقَلَمِ ﴿٤﴾ • **who taught by means of the pen** → the verse appears in the same calm style, with the translation "who taught by [means of] the pen" and "96:4". • **a whole civilisation** → the verse fades out completely and the canvas warms back to ivory. • **picked up the pen** → a single gold line draws itself like a pen stroke, and the camera pulls back: the line is the first link of a knowledge graph, with compass circles sketching the geometric grid behind it.

BEAT	VOICEOVER = CAPTIONS	ON SCREEN
6 · Baghdad 0:29.5–0:35.5	"At **Baghdad's House of Wisdom**, **al-Khwarizmi's** book gave us '**algebra**'. His name gave us '**algorithm**'."	• **Baghdad's** → the line runs to the first node, and a glass card snaps open, labelled "Baghdad · 9th century". • **House of Wisdom** → the card's title types in. • **al-Khwarizmi's** → a credit chip with his full name. There's no portrait. • **algebra** → the Arabic word الجبر (al-jabr), from his book's title, appears. Its letters slide apart and resettle as "algebra". • **algorithm** → his name decodes letter by letter: al-Khwārizmī → Algoritmi → algorithm. It lands in a phone search bar.
7 · Fez 0:35.5–0:41.5	"In **859**, **Fatima al-Fihri** founded **al-Qarawiyyin** in Fez. It's **still teaching today**."	• **859** → the line runs to the second node, and "859" counts up and lands. • **Fatima al-Fihri** → a founder chip in magenta. There's no figure. • **al-Qarawiyyin** → a horseshoe arch draws itself in line art. • **still teaching today** → a live status pill reads "● Still teaching · 1,167 years", with a pulsing green dot. Source tag: "Guinness World Records".
8 · Manchester 0:41.5–0:49.5	"And in **Manchester**, a college built in **1843** is **still a place of learning**: the **British Muslim Heritage Centre**."	• **Manchester** → the line sweeps to the third node and the camera follows. • **1843** → a tag: "Built 1843 · Lancashire Independent College". • **still a place of learning** → the building from BMHC's logo draws itself stroke by stroke, then its windows light up. • **British Muslim Heritage Centre** → the logo's four colour bars slide in under the building.
9 · Today 0:49.5–0:56.5	"**Qur'an classes**, **study circles**, **exhibitions** and **youth clubs**, for over **130,000** visitors a year."	• Each programme springs out of the building as a glass chip on its own word, in one of the logo's colours: **Qur'an classes** teal, **study circles** green, **exhibitions** orange, **youth clubs** magenta. • **130,000** → a counter rolls up to "130K+ visitors a year".
10 · Payoff 0:56.5–1:03	"It all began with **one word**." A one-second pause. "So, **what will you read next?**"	• **one word** → the camera pulls right back. The "Read" node (labelled "Hira, near Makkah") and the three city nodes sit on four points of one eight-pointed star. The knowledge graph is an Islamic geometric pattern. One second of stillness. • **what will you read next?** → the four empty points glow softly. At the nearest one the search bar returns with a blinking cursor, "What will you read next?", and a small line: "Tell us in the comments".
11 · End card 1:03–1:08	"**Find a class** at **bmhc dot org dot uk**."	• **Find a class** → the star folds into the BMHC logo, with "Find a class at". • **bmhc dot org dot uk** → "bmhc.org.uk" types in, with "College Road, Whalley Range, Manchester M16 8BP" beneath.

Short cut (about 35 s) for Stories or ads: beats 1–4, then 8 (starting "In Manchester…") and 11, leaving the verse with the same slow fade as beat 5. For paid ads, lift the lower captions about 150 px to clear Meta's bottom safe area.

LOOK, MOTION AND SOUND

Palette: BMHC's own website colours

Deep green	Ivory	Teal	Gold	Magenta	Orange	Green
#122F2A · text, the verse	#EFEEEA · the canvas	#09999C · main accent	#DD9933 · the pen line	#DB225E · chips	#F26721 · chips	#76BF43 · chips

Type

- **Poppins**, the BMHC website's typeface, for the captions, cards and search bar.
- **KFGQPC Uthmanic Script Hafs** (King Fahd Complex, the font Quran.com uses) for the Qur'anic text, set from Quran.com's matching QPC Hafs text. The frames here use it too.
- **Amiri** for other Arabic, such as الجبر, and for ﷺ, which Poppins doesn't include.

Motion (After Effects)

- **One continuous camera** moves over an endless canvas, with no hard cuts. The only dissolves are into and out of the verse.
- **UI moves on soft springs** (about 8% overshoot, settling in 12 frames). The verse only ever moves with slow, gentle eases.
- **Lines draw on with trim paths**, and nodes land with a small pulse ring.
- **Word morphs** (al-jabr → algebra, al-Khwārizmī → algorithm) use a 10-frame decode. They are only used on these everyday words, never on sacred text.
- **Counters** use fixed-width numbers and ease out.
- **Depth** comes from three parallax layers (grid, lines, cards), a light depth of field and motion blur.
- **The geometric grid** builds itself from compass circles, like a hand-drawn construction. It is the design system every card snaps to.

Captions

- Poppins SemiBold, two lines at most, placed in the middle of the frame, inside Instagram's safe area.
- The spoken word lights up teal as it's said.
- In sacred mode the captions are still, whole lines, with nothing popping.

Sound

- **No music.** The soundtrack is the voiceover, the imam's recitation and soft UI sounds: ticks for chips, a pen scratch for the gold line, airy whooshes for camera moves and a soft pop on "130K+". No bells or chimes.
- **Silence under the verse**, apart from the recitation and the narrator.
- **A calm British narrator**, recorded by a person, who pronounces Iqra, al-Khwārizmī, al-Fihri and al-Qarawiyyin correctly.
- Mix the voice at about -16 LUFS and the master at -14 LUFS for Instagram.

Format

- 1080×1920, 30 fps, H.264, about 68 seconds. Export a cover frame (see the Instagram kit).

RESPECTING ISLAMIC GUIDELINES

- **No people or animals on screen.** There are no faces, figures or silhouettes, and never any depiction of the Prophet ﷺ, angels or the Companions. People appear only as names, and places only as line art.
- **The Qur'anic text is exact.** It's taken from a verified Uthmani mushaf source (Quran.com, King Fahd Complex script) and checked by BMHC's imam before animating. It is never typed out, scrambled, morphed, mirrored, cropped, bounced or covered by UI, and its reference is always shown.
- **The recitation is by a qualified person**, ideally BMHC's own imam. Don't use AI recitation, or an AI voice reading Arabic verses.
- **The Prophet's name** has ﷺ on screen and "peace be upon him" in the voiceover.
- **No music, and no sound effects under the verse.** Nothing humorous or gimmicky goes near sacred text; the pace slows right down around it.
- **The quiz treats every answer with respect.** Pray, Fast and Give simply fade, with no crosses or "wrong" sounds.
- **Every fact has a source.** The hadith are from Sahih al-Bukhari, and the history is from Guinness World Records, Britannica and BMHC's own history page. There are no exaggerated "Muslims invented everything" claims.

This document contains Qur'anic text. Please handle printed copies with respect.

INSTAGRAM KIT

Post caption

The first word of the Qur'an to be revealed was Iqra: Read.

From the House of Wisdom in Baghdad, to al-Qarawiyyin in Fez, to our classrooms in Whalley Range today, that word has kept people learning for over 1,400 years.

So, what will you read next? Tell us in the comments 👇

Find a Qur'an class, study circle or exhibition at the link in our bio.

#BMHC #Iqra #MuslimHeritage #IslamicHistory #Manchester

Cover

The ivory canvas with the search bar reading **"The first word revealed was…"** and one blurred chip below it. It makes people curious without giving the answer away. Keep the bar and chip inside the central 1080×1440, because the profile grid crops covers to 3:4.

Pinned comment

"Did you guess it before the answer? Comment 'Iqra' if you did 🤍"

Story follow-up

Share the reel to Stories with Instagram's quiz sticker: "What was the first word revealed?" with Read, Pray, Fast and Give as the options.

PINTEREST REFERENCES

We searched Pinterest for Islamic motion graphics, Arabic calligraphy animation, Islamic geometric line art, SaaS motion design, dark green and gold glass UI, and kinetic caption typography. We used the results to see what's common, then built something different.

What's everywhere (we avoid it)

- Lanterns, crescent moons, mosque silhouettes, gold mandalas and purple night skies. It's the greeting-card look of most Ramadan and Eid posts.
- Busy calligraphy effects such as glitter, fire and liquid gold. They aren't right for Qur'anic text.

What we borrow and combine

- **From SaaS launch reels:** a search bar with a blinking cursor, connected word chips, floating glass cards, status pills and counters.
- **From Islamic geometry:** patterns built live from compass circles, used here as the grid everything snaps to.
- **From calligraphy reels:** one phrase, revealed slowly by light on deep green.
- **From kinetic captions:** word-by-word highlighting that follows the voice.

SOURCES FOR EVERY FACT

- **Qur'an 96:1 and 96:4:** Arabic in Uthmani script, translation by M.A.S. Abdel Haleem (Oxford). Both via Quran.com.
- **The first revelation:** Sahih al-Bukhari 3 (96:1–3) and 4953 (96:1–5), narrated by Aisha.
- **al-Khwārizmī, the House of Wisdom, "algebra" and "algorithm":** Encyclopaedia Britannica. Algebra comes from *al-jabr* in his book's title, and algorithm from *Algoritmi*, the Latin form of his name.
- **al-Qarawiyyin, founded in 859:** Guinness World Records, "the oldest existing, and continually operating educational institution in the world". 2026 - 859 = 1,167 years. **Founded by Fatima al-Fihri:** muslimheritage.com (Foundation for Science, Technology and Civilisation).
- **The 1843 building and Lancashire Independent College:** bmhc.org.uk/history. **130K+ visitors a year, and the programmes:** bmhc.org.uk.

NEXT IN THE SERIES: "ONE WORD"

The same format works as a series, with each episode tracing one word from the Qur'an or Sunnah to the Centre today:

- **Sadaqah:** the good deeds that keep going after us (Sahih Muslim 1631), leading to BMHC's Sadaqah Jariyah projects and the donate page.
- **Salam:** the greeting that builds love between people (Sahih Muslim 54), leading to BMHC's open days and interfaith work.
- **Salah:** prayer at its prescribed times (Qur'an 4:103, the verse BMHC already uses on its prayer timetable), leading to the monthly Manchester prayer times.